

Usability Heuristics for Interface Design

Sample document written for RAG practice. General information only.

What a heuristic is

A usability heuristic is a broad rule of thumb for judging an interface. Heuristics do not replace user testing, but they help a designer find obvious problems quickly and cheaply. A heuristic evaluation usually involves three to five reviewers who each inspect the interface alone, list problems against the heuristics, and then combine their findings.

Visibility of system status

Users should always know what the system is doing. A progress bar during an upload, a spinner while data loads, and a confirmation message after saving are all examples. When feedback is missing, people click again, reload the page, or assume that the app is broken.

Match between system and the real world

Use words, phrases and concepts the user already understands, not internal jargon. A booking app should say Check-in date rather than Start timestamp. Follow real-world conventions and present information in a natural, logical order.

User control and freedom

People make mistakes and need a clearly marked emergency exit. Undo, redo and cancel buttons reduce anxiety and encourage exploration. A destructive action such as deleting an account should ask for confirmation and, where possible, be reversible.

Consistency and error prevention

The same action should look and behave the same way everywhere. Follow platform conventions so users do not have to wonder whether different words or icons mean the same thing. Better than good error messages is a design that prevents errors: disable buttons that cannot be used yet, suggest valid formats, and confirm before irreversible steps.

Recognition rather than recall

Minimise the user's memory load by making options, actions and information visible. A menu that lists recent files is easier to use than one that requires typing a file name from memory. Help should be easy to search and focused on the user's task, with concrete steps.